

Strong bond: Aunshuman Gaekwad had a special relationship with Sachin Tendulkar and Mohammad Azharuddin. He was a fan of their batting styles. THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY

Gaekwad promptly presented himself to the captain. "I rang his doorbell and asked him what I should do." Pataudi's reply floored him: "Find out for yourself. No one told me when I made my debut." As Gaekwad discovered, it was a prank by Pataudi, who wanted the young cricketer from Baroda to back himself.

When Pataudi passed away in 2011, Gaekwad, who received the news late at night, took an early morning flight to reach Pataudi's home village to attend the final rites. His respect for the iconic cricketer was immense. Though he enjoyed smoking, Gaekwad never did so in Pataudi's presence. He belonged to the old school, where a captain, guru, or teacher was revered.

His name always rekindled memories of a dogged and fearless individual. Although he was not the most attractive batter to watch, he was the captain's first choice because of his ability to blunt an attack. He loved dropping the ball dead at his feet and checking the bowler's expressions. "It was my favourite pastime to convey to the bowler that his best effort to get me out was futile," he once told *Sportstar*.

One such gesture nearly proved fatal for him.

Sabina Park, 1976. The West Indies were on a vengeful trip to harm the Indians. "It was in the air. The West Indian aggression was not to be missed," Gaekwad recalled. One ball from Michael Holding hit him on the fingers, and he was in excruciating pain. Gaekwad angered the bowler with an inappropriate gesture with his finger. The next ball, bowled from around the stump, was dug short and fast. It struck him behind the ear, smashed his spectacles, and sent him to the hospital. "I thought my cricket and life were over."



Gaekwad fought back. His first six Tests were against the West Indies. Six months after the injury, he was back in his position as Gavaskar's opening partner against New Zealand in Bombay (now Mumbai). He featured in 40 Tests and was a gross underachiever for a batter with a first-class career that spanned 22 years.

His debut came in 1970 against a Maharashtra team that included Chandu Borde, Chetan Chauhan, and Hemant Kanitkar. In 1992, his farewell game against Gujarat took him to his beloved Moti Bagh Stadium in Baroda. At 40, he celebrated with knocks of 143 and 10, unbeaten on both occasions. He soon stepped into a new role as a national selector and did a fine job.

Some of my favorite memories with Gaekwad came during his stint as team coach. The Desert Storm episode in Sharjah in 1998 stands out. He told Tendulkar, "I want the trophy," and the maestro did not let him down with two back-to-back centuries. Tendulkar held Gaekwad in high esteem.

A year later, at the 1999 World Cup in England, Gaekwad confessed to facing the "biggest challenge" of his crickering career — breaking the news of Tendulkar's father's demise.

Upon receiving the news, Gaekwad took Tendulkar's wife, Anjali, into confidence to convey the dreaded development. Tendulkar broke down in Gaekwad's arms before leaving for his father's cremation. But he returned to serve the team.

Gaekwad had a special relationship with Tendulkar and Azharuddin. He was a fan of their batting styles. Both added to Gaekwad's hobby of collecting wristwatches as a tribute to his guidance. "I don't wear them. They sit in my drawing room," Gaekwad revealed when I visited his home in Baroda.

Gaekwad's tastefully decorated residence reflects his persona. "It is all the work of [my wife] Jyoti," he insisted. "My job is to take care of the garden. All my vegetables are homegrown." He also proudly pointed to a peacock, which would strut into his kitchen every morning and leave after what Gaekwad called a "pitch inspection."

After serving as a player, selector, and coach for the Board, Gaekwad took up assignments with the Gujarat Cricket Association and later became a member of BCCI's Cricket Advisory Committee. However, he was dissatisfied with these roles and eventually found a way to share his